

Carettochelys insculpta

Pig-nosed river turtle



Length 28–30 in (70–75 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Aquatic
Status Vulnerable

Location S. New Guinea, N. Australia



This unusual Australasian turtle lives in fresh water, but has a number of similarities with turtles that live at sea. Its limbs are broad and flipperlike, with relatively few claws, and its gray-green or grayish brown carapace is covered by a layer of soft skin. The shell has a pitted or sculpted surface. Pig-nosed turtles are active foragers, feeding on snails, small fishes, and fruit. The piglike snout gives them their name. They use the snout to breathe while submerged. Females nest in shallow holes on river banks, laying up to 22 thin-shelled eggs.



Chelonia mydas

Green sea turtle



Length 3¼–4 ft (1–1.2 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Aquatic
Status Endangered

Location Tropical, subtropical, and temperate waters worldwide



This graceful, streamlined swimmer is one of the world's most widespread marine turtles found in tropical and subtropical waters across the globe. Despite its name, it is not invariably green, but it always has distinctive, light edging to the scales on its head and limbs, and on scutes around the edge of its shield-shaped carapace. The adults graze on sea grass, mangrove roots, and leaves, but young green sea turtles are more carnivorous, also eating jellyfish, mollusks, and sponges. In order to breed, green sea turtles make their way to isolated, sandy beaches, sometimes traveling across more than 620 miles (1,000 km) of open water. After mating in shallow water, the females crawl ashore after dark, laying 100–150 eggs in deep pits above the high-tide mark. The young hatch in

Chelodina longicollis

Common snake-necked turtle



Length 8–10 in (20–25 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Semiaquatic
Status Not evaluated

Location E. and S. Australia



With its small head and extremely long neck, this turtle is one of Australia's most distinctive freshwater reptiles.



Together, the head and neck are often longer than the shell, allowing the turtle to lunge at passing prey, such as fishes, tadpoles, and crustaceans. Its long neck also allows it to “snorkel” while resting on the beds of slow-moving rivers or streams, or in swamps and lagoons. In summer, it may make extensive overland migrations to find water. If disturbed, this turtle can emit a foul-smelling fluid from its musk glands. The female lays 6–24 brittle eggs in a nest dug in grassy or sandy areas at night or after rains.

Chelus fimbriatus

Matamata



Length 12–18 in (30–45 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Aquatic
Status Not evaluated

Location N. South America



Most turtles actively seek out their prey, but the knobby shelled matamata lies in wait in shallow, muddy water, using its remarkable camouflage to avoid being seen. Its eyes—set in a triangular head—are small, but it has large external

eardrums and sensory skin flaps that help to detect moving prey. It also has a snorkellike nose, which allows it to breathe without rising to the surface. Female matamatas lay up to 28 eggs in a single nesting.



Platemys platycephala

Twist-necked turtle



Length 5½–6¾ in (14–17 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Semiaquatic
Status Not evaluated

Location N. South America

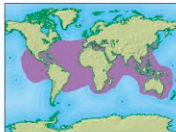


If threatened, this turtle withdraws into its shell by twisting its head onto its side. Also called the flat-headed turtle, this little-known species has an extremely flat shell that may help it hide under rocks and debris. The carapace is dark or chestnut-brown, or yellow with brown patches, with 2 ridges along its length. A poor swimmer, the turtle remains in shallow pools and puddles, or moves around on the forest floor. It forages for aquatic insects, worms, snails, and tadpoles. Females lay a single egg in a shallow scrape or directly on the surface, and cover it with rotting leaves.



Eretmochelys imbricata

Hawksbill turtle

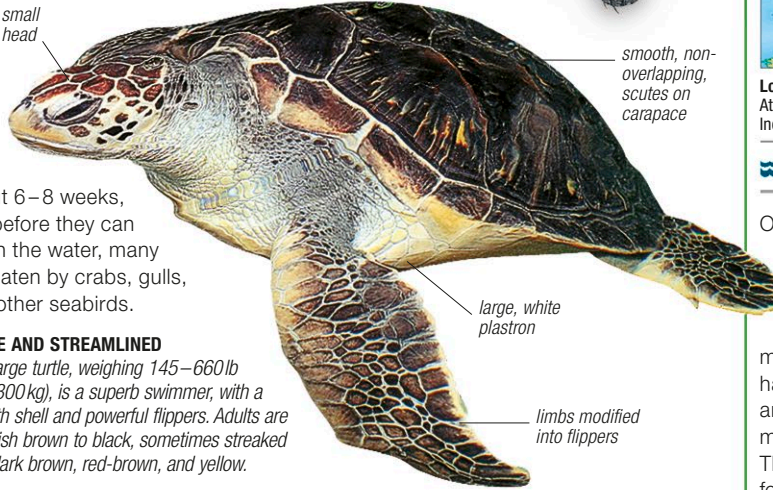


Length 2¾–32 in (60–80 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Aquatic
Status Critically endangered

Location Warmer parts of Atlantic, tropical Indo-Pacific



One of the smallest marine turtles, the hawksbill is easily recognized by its carapace, which has a central keel and serrated edges. Seen closely, its scutes are beautifully marked—the reason why this species has been so widely hunted. Hawksbills are long-lived animals, and are less migratory than other marine turtles. They use their narrow beaks to forage for sponges, mollusks, and other animals on the seabed and among coral reefs.



about 6–8 weeks, but before they can reach the water, many are eaten by crabs, gulls, and other seabirds.

LARGE AND STREAMLINED

This large turtle, weighing 145–660 lb (65–300 kg), is a superb swimmer, with a smooth shell and powerful flippers. Adults are greenish brown to black, sometimes streaked with dark brown, red-brown, and yellow.

CONSERVATION

The green sea turtle has been the main quarry of commercial turtle fishing, which has led to its endangered status. With the disturbance of many breeding beaches, suitable nesting sites are also decreasing. Conservation measures for the green sea turtle include legal protection from hunting and egg harvesting, patrols of nesting beaches, and artificial incubation of eggs so that hatchlings can be given a head start, being released into the wild once past their most vulnerable stage.

